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ENG501

Assignment # 1

Q1(a) Vocabulary Expansion in Old English & Affixes vs. Compound Words

Old English (OE) expanded its vocabulary primarily through **borrowing** and **word formation processes** like compounding and affixation.

1. **Borrowing:** OE absorbed many words from **Latin** due to the Christianization of England and contact with the Roman Empire. Additionally, there were loanwords from Old Norse due to Viking invasions.
2. **Word Formation:**
 - **Affixation:** The process of adding prefixes and suffixes to a base word to create new meanings. However, Old English had fewer affixes than Modern English, and these were often used to create inflected forms rather than derivations (e.g., **-ing** as a suffix to form present participles).
 - **Compounding:** Old English relied heavily on **compounds**—two or more words joined together to form a new word (e.g., **“eorpanædr”** meaning “earth-snake,” which evolved into the word “serpent” in Modern English).

Difference Between Affixes and Compound Words:

- **Affixes:** Attach to the root word to modify or create a new word. Old English used affixes for inflection (to show tense, number, etc.) but not as much for derivation.
- **Compound Words:** Combine two (or more) words to create a new meaning. Old English used compounds more frequently than Modern English, which often prefers affixes over long compounds.

Q1(b) Influence of Christianity on Old English Vocabulary

The advent of **Christianity** in the early medieval period had a significant influence on the vocabulary of Old English. Key areas of impact include:

1. **Latin Borrowings:** As Christianity was introduced to England, Latin became the language of the church. Many religious terms were borrowed from Latin, such as **“god”**, **“biscop”** (bishop), and **“heofon”** (heaven).
2. **Religious Influence:** The spread of Christianity brought with it a variety of new concepts that were previously unknown to the Anglo-Saxons, such as **church**, **sacraments**, **saints**, and religious practices. These concepts required the adoption of new vocabulary or adaptation of existing words to fit new ideas.

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3. **Literature & Education:** Christian missionaries introduced **Latin literature** and religious texts, which resulted in an influx of Latin-derived vocabulary into Old English. Words related to religious practice, philosophy, and church governance became commonplace in Old English.

In summary, Christianity expanded the Old English vocabulary, particularly with terms related to religion, culture, and the Latin language, which influenced the development of the language throughout the medieval period.

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